The timing of the trial fell during the period in which Suu Kyi's house arrest had been scheduled to expire. International condemnation was widespread. The European Union as well as United Nations Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon and numerous representatives from governments across the world called for the release of Suu Kyi as well as other political prisoners.

The majority of the actual case was heard in July with closing arguments delivered late in the month. The verdict was postponed several times, finally being released on August 11. Suu Kyi was found guilty and sentenced to 18 months of house arrest, while John Yettaw received a seven-year term with hard labor.

In late August 2009, Jim Webb, a U.S. senator from Virginia, arrived in Myanmar to work for the release of John Yettaw. The senator, chairman of the Foreign Relations Committee, was allowed a meeting with Aung San Suu Kyi as well as a diplomatic visit with General Than Shwe. This was the first time that a member of the U.S. government had meet with a leader of Myanmar since the pre-1988 period. Webb was not in Myanmar on behalf of the Obama Administration. The visit was thus unofficial in the context of diplomatic relations. Within days, Yettaw was sentenced to be deported by the authorities; he departed with the senator shortly after. Critics of the regime believed the Webb visit was a mistake. Dealing with the junta could be seen as a sign of acceptance of the repressive antidemocratic policies of the SPDC. Webb viewed the visit strictly as a humanitarian mission, which he hoped could lay the foundation for confidence building in the future.

PROGRESS AND HOPE IN MYANMAR

In May 2008, as part of the process toward what the leadership calls the “road map” to democracy, the dictatorship ratified a new constitution, which led to the first elections in over 20 years. The constitution created a civilian-dominated government, with a two-house parliament that would meet once a year, and an elected head of state. Power remains vested in the commander-in-chief of the armed forces with his military council. With the military controlling a quarter of all seats in parliament, they continue to have a monopoly on decision making.

The Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP) is the mechanism that the junta works through. The elections were held on November 7, 2010.